



Modal Verbs in English

CAN: Expressing Ability and Permission

Ability

Example: Phil can speak Japanese fluently.

Shows what someone is capable of doing

Permission

Example: You can use this office whenever you need it.

Gives or asks for permission (informal)

Request

Example: Can you confirm your attendance by Friday?

Asks someone to do something

Possibility

Example: Delays can occur due to technical issues.

Expresses that something is possible

Formula:

🕒 S + can + V(base)

Negative form:

cannot or can't



COULD: Past Ability and Polite Requests

For the Past

Past Ability: When I was younger, I **could** run five kilometres without stopping.

Shows what someone was able to do in the past.



Possibility

The new policy **could** increase efficiency in our department.

Expresses that something is possibly true or possibly might happen (less certain than certain than "can")



Suggestion

We **could** try a new approach to solve this problem.

Offers an idea or option for consideration

Negative form: **could not** or couldn't

For Present/Future

Polite Request: **Could** you please provide more details about the project?

More polite than "can" when asking someone to do something.



MAY: Formal Permission and Possibility

The modal verb "may" is often used in more formal contexts than "can". It indicates either asking for permission in a polite way or expressing that something is possibly true.

Formal Permission

May I come in, Professor?

More formal and polite than "can" when asking for permission.

Possibility

The report may contain some errors, so please review it carefully.

Expresses that something is possibly true (50% chance).



Formula:

 S + may + V(base)

Negative form:

may not

Common in TOEIC:

Visitors may park in designated areas only.

This indicates official permission in formal notices or regulations.

MIGHT: Less Certain Possibility

Less Certain Possibility

We **might** expand our business next year, but we haven't decided yet.

"Might" expresses a lower probability than "may" - perhaps a 30-40% chance.

Reported Speech

John said he **might** be late for the meeting.

Used when reporting what someone said about a possibility

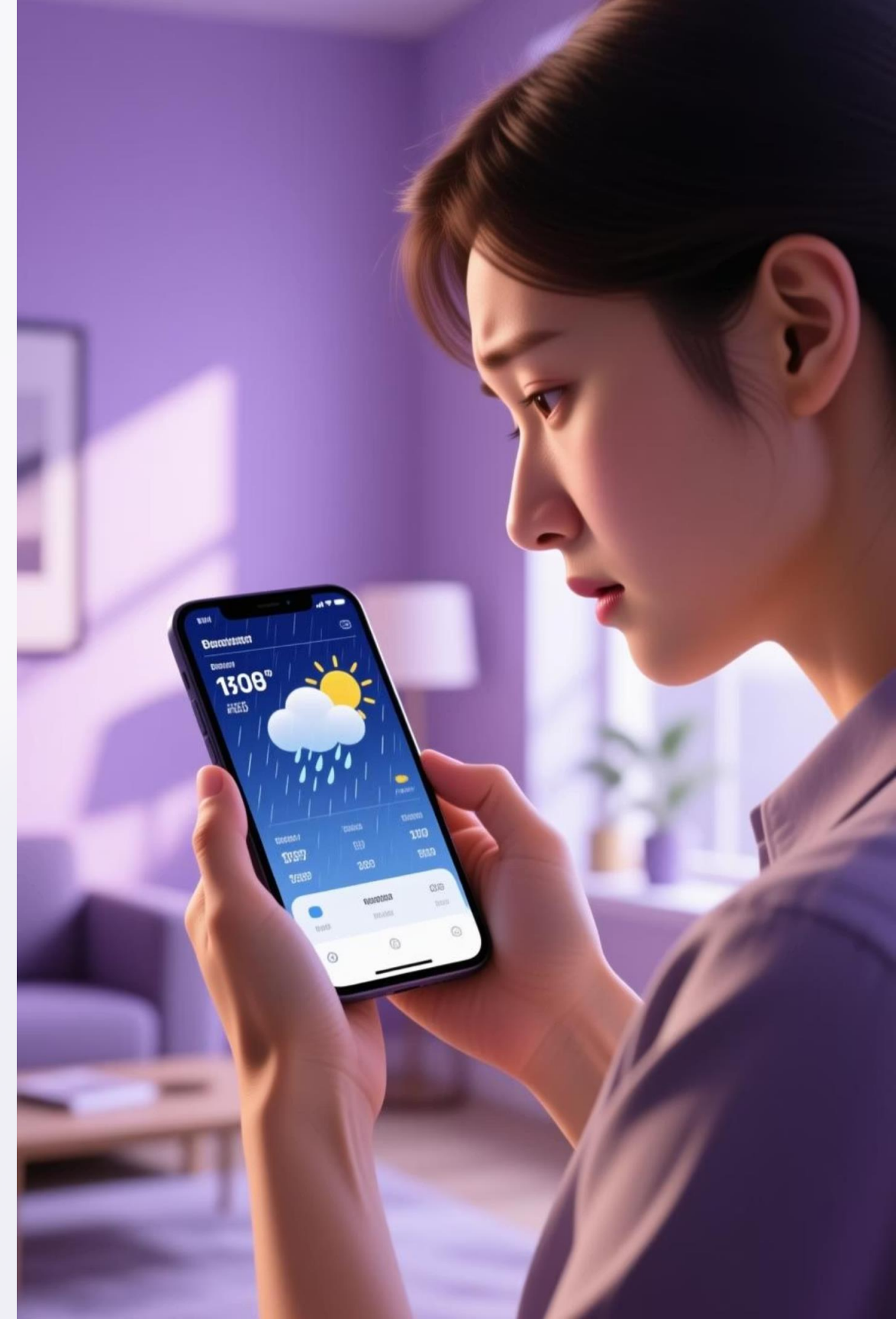
Negative Forms

- **may not** - The delivery may not arrive until tomorrow.
- **might not** - She might not attend the conference.

TOEIC Example

The proposed solution **might not** be the best option for our current situation.

This cautious language is common in business contexts on the TOEIC test.



MUST: Strong Obligation and Logical Deduction

The modal verb "must" is one of the strongest in English, expressing either a firm obligation or a confident logical conclusion.



Strong Obligation

All employees **must** attend the safety training.

Indicates something is absolutely necessary or required

Logical Deduction

You've been working for 12 hours. You **must** be tired!

Expresses a confident conclusion based on evidence

Prohibition

You **must not** park in front of the emergency exit.

Expresses that something is not allowed or forbidden

Remember: "Must not" (prohibition) is stronger than "don't have to" (lack of necessity).

HAVE TO: External Obligation

		
Have to Expresses obligation from external sources (rules, laws, necessity) Example: Applicants have to submit their resumes by Friday.	Can change tense Unlike "must", "have to" can be used in different tenses • Past: had to • Future: will have to	Don't have to Expresses lack of necessity (something is optional) Example: You don't have to work overtime today.



 **Key Difference**

Must = internal obligation (speaker's authority)

Have to = external obligation (rules, laws)

Compare:

- I **must** study harder. (I decide this)
- I **have to** wear a uniform. (School rule)

SHOULD & OUGHT TO: Advice and Expectation

Advice

You **should** review your notes before the exam.

Recommends the best course of action.

Responsibility

Employees **should** arrive at work on time.

Indicates what is correct or expected.

Expectation

The new software **should** improve processing speed.

Expresses what we expect to happen.

Negative forms:

- **shouldn't** (should not)
- **ought not to** (less common)

Note: "Ought to" has similar meaning to "should" but is less common in everyday speech.

The strength of obligation with "should" is weaker than "must" but stronger than "could".



Perfect Modals: Referring to the Past

Perfect modals combine modal verbs with "have + past participle" to talk about past possibilities, obligations, or speculation.

